

500 employees who work from home and compared them to 500 who went to the office. The survey showed that those who worked from home saved considerable amounts of both time and money because there was no need to commute to work. Those who work from home just have more time to put into work, and on average, this results in about 17 additional work days per employee over the course of a year. The survey also identified the areas in which those who work from home struggled the most. Those who worked remotely were more stressed about the work, procrastinated more, felt more overwhelmed or bogged down, and showed low levels of motivation. On the plus side, those who worked from home are less likely to avoid interactions with co-workers.

TAKE CARE OF YOUR DEVICES

Now, irrespective of whether you are working from home or in the office, and also irrespective of an ongoing pandemic, it is always a good idea to periodically sanitise your devices. This is because, over time, there can be a build up of various vectors that can spread diseases, microbes, as well as toxic microparticles. In a simple experiment, students from the University of Surrey in the UK imprinted smartphones on petri dishes with food for bacteria showed that smartphone screens can be dirtier than even toilet seats. While most of the bacteria found were benign, there were some that could cause health problems, including those that are responsible for skin infections.

One of the easy precautions to take is to make sure that your devices do not get filthy in the first place. Do not eat or drink while working on your computer, or at least make sure that there are no crumbs falling into the keyboard. Also be mindful of hairfall and dandruff. As always, it is a good idea to thoroughly wash your hands before handling devices. If you have a disgusting sheen of oily crud smeared all over your keys or trackpad, you are doing it wrong.

Now, periodically cleaning your desktop computer involves removing all the wiring. You do not need to disassemble all the components, but it is a good idea to give the PC a deep clean at least once or twice a year. If you have



Credit: University of Surrey

An experiment that showed the bacteria accumulated on a smartphone

no idea how to build a machine, it is a good idea to understand the innards of your computers too. It is not that difficult, and there is very little you can do wrong. All the wires and ports are designed in such a way, that they will only fit in where they are supposed to. Be careful about this, and don't jam or force anything, and don't make the screws too tight. For a laptop with removable batteries, it is a good idea to take them out and clean the battery bay as well. Then you can use a rubber air blowing bulb to remove the dust and crumbs from the keyboard. Use a clean, soft piece of cloth to wipe the keyboard and mouse, or the trackpad on a laptop. A microfibre cloth, the kind used to

wipe sunglasses or spectacles are ideal for the purpose. Tissue paper with just a little bit of water works well too, and a drop or two of hand sanitiser can be used. Isopropyl alcohol with soft cloth can also be used as a disinfectant. The same approach can be used to sanitise all screens, from monitors to smartphones. Be gentle, and do not put too much downward pressure. However, do not use detergents or god forbid, bleach, acetone, ammonia, any solvents, or the abrasive chemicals used to clean the floor or sinks on your delicate electronic instruments. For smartphones, there are also UV light blasters that promise to nuke away all the microbes with a photon shower. Zeiss makes wipes specially designed for mobile screens. Remember to clean out the insides of the smartphone case as well. Cotton ear swabs or buds can be used to clean the speakers, the charging ports and the areas around the buttons and toggles. A small, thin paintbrush with soft bristles can also be used for this purpose. If there is dust build up, an air blower can be used (don't get too smart and use a hair dryer, that can damage the electronics).

HAVING FUN

Now, staying at home all day can just drive you mad. This is because after a while, you just run out of things to talk about on video calls, and it is great

APPS THAT SIMPLIFY WORKING FROM HOME



Toggl: Toggl is a time tracking app with an idle detection feature that lets individuals or teams keep track of how much time it takes to get things done.



Trello: A project scheduling and tracking tool that breaks down each job into individual tasks that can be timed and shared with bosses or even clients.



Chrome remote desktop: An alternative to TeamViewer that allows you to remotely access your desktop from another

computer or even a smartphone, through the Chrome browser.



Slack: This is a powerful app that can help teams stay focused on various tasks through the creation of channels. The service supports multiple plugins, and is very flexible.



Daywise: An Android only app that lets you focus on important tasks and removes distractions by filtering notifications and letting only the important ones through. You can catch up to all the notifications once your work is done.